

Module 2

Early Child Development



Module 2 Introduction to Early Child Development

Background

Early child development is a critical phase that lays the foundation for a child's future well-being and success. Understanding the importance of the developmental period is essential for parents, caregivers, and educators.

Concept of Growth and Development

This session provides a comprehensive overview of growth and development and explains how children progress physically, cognitively, emotionally, and socially during their early years. It also highlights the stages of development that include Prenatal, Infancy, Toddlerhood, and Early childhood and its characteristics.

Developmental Domain

Early experiences significantly impact brain architecture and influence lifelong learning, behavior, and health. This highlights the importance of providing nurturing, stimulating, and supportive environments from the earliest stages of life. The session will cover the key developmental domains, including Physical, Cognitive, Language, Social, and Emotional Development. It will also highlight the importance of sensitive periods and emphasize the concept of serve-and-return interactions, demonstrating how responsive caregiving and back-and-forth exchanges between a child and caregiver foster brain development. In addition, the session provides an understanding of the types of stress—positive, tolerable, and toxic and its effects on a child's development. Without adequate support, stress can lead to negative effects on brain development and overall health. The session will also discuss Erik Erikson's Psychosocial Development Theory, the importance of play in the early years, play with low-cost and no-cost contextually relevant materials, and the forms of play in the past and present. By addressing these core areas, the "Early Child Development" module aims to equip participants with the knowledge and tools necessary to support and enhance the developmental trajectories of young children. Through a blend of theoretical insights and practical strategies, learners will gain a holistic understanding of early child development, ensuring that they can foster a conducive environment for children's healthy growth and development.

2.1. Concept of Growth and Development	
Name of the Session	Concept of Growth and Development
Time	105 minutes
Learning Outcomes By the end of the session, participants will be able to: • Identify the difference between growth and development. • Recognise and discuss the stages of development. • Identify the importance of child development and the role of parents/ caregivers in it.	
Session Resources/ Materials • Power-point presentation • Basic stationery • Storybook ‘The Very Hungry Caterpillar’ by Eric Carle	
Concepts/ Themes to be Covered • Growth and Development • Stages of Development • Importance of Child Development • Role of parents in their child’s development	
Activity 01: Interview and Share (20 minutes) Instructions: • Pair participants and have them interview each other. • Ask the pairs to share one important life experience, one challenge, and one personal growth. • Encourage participants to share their partner's story with the larger group. • Introduce the topic to the participants.	
Activity 2: Growth and Development (20 minutes) Instructions: • Ask the participants to answer the following questions in a word: ✓ What is growth? ✓ What is development? • Take maximum responses. • Explain to participants the difference between growth and development with the help of the facilitator’s notes.	

Facilitator's Notes**Difference between Growth and Development**

Growth is related to the changes in size, weight, and height of any individual, it can be measured in terms of numbers. On the other hand, development is related to the changes in all aspects of an individual such as physical development, mental development, emotional development, social development, and motor development. It is sometimes not measurable in terms of numbers but requires some specific tests to measure. Growth is limited to a certain end, and it does not take place beyond that whereas the process of development is long, and it continues throughout life.

Activity 2: Stages of Development- Life Timeline Mapping (45 minutes)**Instructions:**

- Provide white paper and markers to the participants.
- Ask the participants to draw a visual representation of their life journey, including highs, lows, and turning points. For example, starting school, college, or learning a new skill.
- Invite a few participants to share their maps with the large group.
- Discuss the patterns and themes that emerge.
- Ask the participants: How many stages can you see in these timelines?
- Explain to the participants the stage of the development mentioned in the facilitator's notes.

Facilitator's Notes**Stages of Development**

Prenatal stage: "Prenatal age" refers to the period before birth or during pregnancy. During this period developmental stages of a fetus are measured in weeks or months from conception. Monitoring in prenatal age is very important to assess the health of both the fetus and mother to provide needed health care. To ensure a healthy pregnancy, the growth and development of the fetus are observed through antenatal care check-ups and visits to health centres.

Infancy: Infancy is the age from birth to the age of one year. During this period rapid growth occurs both physically and cognitively. Infants experience significant changes and progress from a period of high dependency to developmental milestones such as motor skills development, language development, and social bonds that are typical during infancy. Caregivers play a fundamental role in providing responsive care, creating a secure attachment, and promoting a nurturing environment that supports the infant's exploration and learning opportunities. Understanding and addressing the unique needs of infants during this critical period is essential for promoting their overall well-being and setting the stage for a healthy and thriving childhood. World Health Organization. (2010).

Toddlerhood: Toddlerhood usually ranges from one to three years of age. During this time the toddlers grow significantly in terms of their physical, cognitive, and socio-emotional development. Toddlers become more independent as they begin to walk, learn new words, and self-feed. Caregivers will notice great strides in their child's motor skills, as they walk more confidently, learn to run, and play in more challenging environments.

The toddler stage is critical for establishing a sense of autonomy and curiosity about the world. Caregivers need to provide a safe and stimulating environment that supports exploration and encourages the development of foundational skills.

Early Childhood: The period between three- and six years is known as early childhood. In this phase, growth continues in several areas including physical, cognitive, social, and emotional development. Early childhood is important for future learning experiences, making it a critical period for providing positive and enriching environments that support holistic development.



Activity 3: Importance of Growth and Development (20 minutes)

Instructions:

- Tell the story 'The Very Hungry Caterpillar' to the participants.
- Ask the participants the following questions:
- What came out of the egg?
- Why was the caterpillar searching for food?
- What did he turn into at the end?
- What was the story about?
- Explain to the participants how the caterpillar went through these stages of development and turned into a butterfly by having sufficient food and, a suitable environment to explore. If any one of its needs was not fulfilled it would not survive and not turn into a butterfly.
- Tell participants that in the same way, a child needs adequate support to thrive to reach his/her optimum potential.
- Share some importance of child development and how parents can support the healthy development of their child, mentioned in the facilitator's notes.

Facilitator's Notes

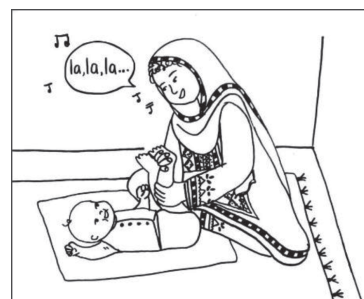
Importance of Child Development

Child development is crucial as it lays the foundation for a child's overall well-being and future success. That is why its importance cannot be overlooked. Below are some significances of child development:

- **Foundation for lifelong learning:** The early years are a critical period for brain development. Cognitive skills, language acquisition, and problem-solving abilities are developed during this time, providing the basis for future academic success.
- **Social and Emotional Wellbeing:** Child development is closely linked to the formation of social and emotional skills. Building healthy relationships, understanding, and expressing emotions, and developing empathy are essential for overall mental health.
- **Physical Wellbeing:** Proper physical development is important for a child's overall health. Nutrition, exercise, and proper healthcare including vaccination during childhood contribute to physical well-being and can impact long-term health outcomes.
- **Cultural and Moral Values:** Children absorb values and beliefs from their environment. Positive influences help shape a child's character, moral compass, and cultural identity.
- **Preparation of Adulthood:** Early experiences and learning opportunities prepare children for the challenges of adulthood. Skills such as decision-making, problem-solving, and effective communication start to develop during the early years.
- **Mental Health:** Positive early experiences and a supportive environment contribute to mental health and resilience. Early intervention for any developmental challenges or mental health issues is crucial for addressing problems before they become more complex.
- **Long-Term Impact on Society:** The development of children shapes the future of society. Investing in early childhood development can have long-lasting effects on societal well-being, influencing factors such as crime rates, educational achievement, and public health.

Parents can support their children by:

- Providing a safe and clean environment at home.
- Giving love and emotional support to build a strong bond between them.
- Giving opportunity to explore their surroundings through play.
- Engaging in talk to enhance communication skills.
- Reading books and singing songs.
- Promoting good eating (balanced diet) and hygiene habits.



- Creating a predictable routine for activity time, mealtime, bedtime, and other activities.
- Encouraging interaction with other children.
- Modelling positive behaviour and values.
- Involving in little acts of kindness
- Involving in age-appropriate household chores
- Supporting and nurturing their interest and talent
- Attending parent-teacher meetings (PTM) and helping them with their school tasks.



Key Takeaways: Concept of Growth and Development

- Child development is the scientific study of the quantitative (height, weight) and qualitative (skills, nature of intelligence) ways in which children change over time.
- Children develop through a series of stages, for example walking, talking, managing feelings, managing emotions, and relating with others.
- Besides individual differences, children have some similar patterns or periods of development. However, there may be small individual differences in typical development, for example, the age when your baby starts to walk.
- Children help to shape their development, parents and caregivers should understand and follow the child's lead.
- The father's contribution to a child's growth and development is unique from the mother's, hence the involvement of the father is as important as the mother's.
- Learning about the changes children experience in their development over time helps parents to identify problems and intervene early.
- In some cases, children may have learning problems and difficulties. With all difficulties, the earlier you identify them, the higher the success of treatment for them.
- Parents/ caregivers can get support from professionals and get a valid diagnosis and treatment plan.

2.2. Developmental Domain

Name of the Session	Developmental Domain
Time	525 minutes
Learning Outcomes By the end of the session, participants will be able to: • Identify and explore the main domains of child development. • Find out how early relationships build child brain architectures. • Discuss ways that promote optimal brain development. • Recognise the importance of brain development in early years. • Equip parents and caregivers with strategies to foster healthy child development. • Identify the importance of physical activities in children's development. • Explore and practice activities that support development.	
Session Resources/Materials • Power-point presentation • Basic stationery • Video resources	
Concepts /Themes to be Covered • Developmental Domains • Brain Development • Stress and its impact on Brain Development. • Psychosocial Development • Psychosocial Development Theory of Eric Erickson • Physical Development • Play in the Early Year	
Activity 01: Developmental Domains - Energizer- Spot the Difference (15 minutes) Instructions: • Divide the participants into two groups, Group A and Group B. • Each group will have an equal number of participants. • Ask the groups to stand in a straight line facing each other. • Once the groups are settled, ask them to listen and follow the instructions: ○ Tell them that the person standing facing you is your pair. ○ Ask group A to look at their pairs carefully for 30 seconds and then turn to the opposite side. ○ Ask Group B to change any three things about the way they look, for example, change their hairstyle/ hold a purse/ put on glasses, etc. ○ Ask group A to turn back and try to spot the differences in their pairs.	

- Now ask group B to observe their pairs for 30 seconds and turn to the opposite side.
- Group A will change any three things.
- Group B will turn and check the difference in their pairs.
- Repeat the same one more time, this time ask to change only one thing.
- After the activity, ask the participants: What did you use while doing this activity?
- Give a hint if they don't get the question, like, what were you using while observing the changes in your pair?
- Later, introduce the domain of development mentioned in the facilitator's note.
- Then again, ask the participants to relate each action they did with the domain.
 - You were using your mind while remembering the appearance of your pair.
 - You use your hand and whole body for this activity.
 - You speak when you share the change in your pairs.
 - You were showing your emotions throughout the activity- smiling, confused, excited.
- Tell the participants that we will discuss the domains in detail.

Facilitator's Notes

Developmental Domains refer to specific areas of a child's growth and progress. Each child develops at their own pace. Many factors such as the environment, age, and genetics can impact how and when a child develops.

1: Physical development refers to the changes in the physical appearance of the body like height, weight, and muscle strengthening. It is also known as motor development. Physical development can be divided into two main groups:

- Fine motor skills – coloring, holding, tearing, etc.
- Gross motor skills – crawling, walking, running, etc.

2: Cognitive development includes the abilities associated with learning, thinking, problem-solving, and expressing.

3: Language development refers to the abilities of talking/ expressing and understanding words and sentences.

4: Social-Emotional development focuses on social interactions and the ability to express emotions, and understand feelings and emotions of self and others, for example, playing with others, taking turns, showing kindness, etc.

Activity 02: Brain Development- Web Building (Connections) (15 minutes)

Instructions:

- Ask the following questions from the participants:
 - When does brain development begin?
 - What helps the brain to develop?

- Write the responses on the whiteboard and later briefly talk about their responses.
- Now ask participants to sit in a circle.
- Instruct the activity:
 - One participant will get a woollen ball to hold and describe an activity he/ she likes to do with his/ her young child (or would do if they had one)
 - Then toss the woollen ball randomly to someone across from you after calling the person's name.
 - Once the woollen ball reaches each participant, point to the web that has been created and ask to relate this to the session's topic. What does this web represent?
- After their responses tell the participants that this web represents the connections (pathways) of brain cells (neurons) in the brain.

Activity 03: Brain Development- Video and Discussion (30 minutes)

Instructions:

- Show the following video:

<https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=zJacoOMINM4>

- After the video, ask some of the participants to tell what the video shows.
- Later discuss the importance of brain development with the help of the facilitator's notes.

***Note:** For the participants of group two, explain the key points from the video for their understanding.*

Facilitator's Notes

From conception to age 5, a child's brain develops more rapidly than at any other time in life. Early brain development has a lasting impact on a child's ability to learn and achieve success in school and life. The early experiences whether positive or negative, significantly influence the development of a child's brain.

90% of Brain Growth Happens by the age of Five.

At the time of birth, an average baby's brain is about one fourth of the size of the average adult brain. Remarkably, it doubles in size in the first year and reaches 80% by the age of 3. And by that age, it grows around 90%.

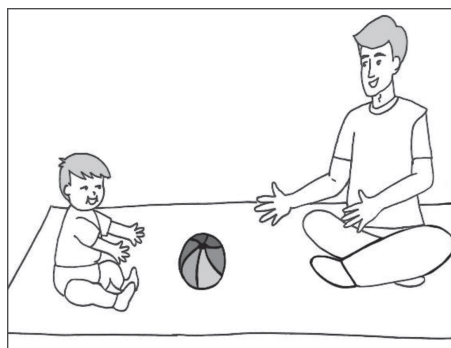
The brain serves as the command center for the human body. Although a new born baby has all the brain cells they will have throughout their life, it is the connections between these cells that play a vital role in the functionality of the brain. These connections help us to think, talk, move, and many other activities. The early years of childhood are crucial for establishing these connections, with at least one million new neural connections forming every second, surpassing any other period in life. Each area of the brain has different abilities such as movement, language, and emotion, and they develop at varying rates. In the early years, a child's brain establishes vital connections that are very important for their future well-being and success as adults.

The Brain Connections

From birth, the connection of the brain cells begins through daily experiences. Positive interactions with parents and caregivers, as well as using their senses to engage with the world, contribute to the formation of these connections. The everyday experiences of a young child play a vital role in determining which brain connections develop and which last throughout their lifetime. The quantity and quality of care, stimulation, and interaction they receive during their early years significantly impact the outcome.

Stimulating and Learning

The brain's capacity for learning is particularly high during early development. Stimulation through various activities, such as reading, playing, and exploring, enhances synaptic connections and cognitive capacities.



Sensitive Period

There are critical periods in early brain development when certain skills and abilities are most easily acquired. Providing appropriate stimuli during these periods enhances the development of essential functions. For example, in language development, there is a sensitive period during which exposure to language is crucial for acquiring native-like proficiency. If a child is not exposed to language during this period, it becomes significantly more challenging for them to develop language skills later.

Caring, Responsive Relationships (Serve and Return)

From the time of birth, young children actively seek engagement with their parents and other adult caregivers. Infants express this through cooing, smiling, and crying, while toddlers communicate more directly about their needs and interests. Each of these invitations serves as an opportunity for caregivers to be responsive to the child's needs. Positive interactions between children and caregivers during early childhood, often described as "serve and return," play an important role in wiring the brain. Responsive caregiving fosters healthy emotional and cognitive development.



Adverse Childhood Experiences

Children who experience more positive interactions in their early years go on to be healthier and more successful both in school and in life. On the other hand, children who experience poverty, exposure to family violence, and a lack of access to early learning experiences can have effects on a child's early brain development, potentially influencing their long-term success negatively.

Activity 4: Brain Learn Before Birth- Case Study (15 minutes)**Instructions:**

- Ask the participants ‘When does a brain begin to learn?’
- Take random responses and ask the participants to justify their answers.
- Read the case studies ‘The Cat in the Hat’ and ‘The Carrot Juice’, shared in the facilitator’s notes.
- Discuss the studies in the large group.
- End the discussion by sharing that these studies show that a baby starts learning before birth.

Facilitator’s Notes**Case Study1: The Cat in the Hat**

DeCasper and Spence had 16 pregnant mothers read a three-minute-long passage from the Dr. Seuss book ‘The Cat in the Hat’ to their foetuses twice a day for the last 6.5 weeks of pregnancy. The mothers were also recorded reading three-minute excerpts from two other stories. By the time the babies were born, the researchers calculated, they had heard ‘The Cat in the Hat’ for about 5 hours. DeCasper and Spence used their sucking test. The babies sucked more to hear The Cat in the Hat, regardless of whether it was in their mother's voice or another woman's voice if that was the story they heard in the womb (Kolata, 1984).

Case Study 2: The Carrot Juice

Julie Mennella, a researcher at the Monell Chemical Senses Centre in Philadelphia, divided 46 women in the last trimester of pregnancy into three groups: Those who drank carrot juice during pregnancy and water during lactation; those who did the opposite; and those who drank only water. Then, when the infants were about 6 months old and eating solid food, they were given cereal prepared either with water or with carrot juice. The babies exposed to carrot flavour either prenatally or in breast milk were much more enthusiastic about the carrot porridge than the plain mix; the other infants didn't show a preference, Mennella's team reported at a symposium of the American Psychological Society in Miami last month.

Activity 05: Serve and Return (20 minutes)**Instructions:**

- Ask the participants the following questions:
 - What is meant by “serve and return”?
 - What is its role in the process of brain development?
- After taking their points, explain to the participants the importance of “serve and return” in brain development.

Facilitator’s Notes

‘Serve and Return’ is an important element in the process of healthy brain development. Parents and caregivers who give attention, respond, and interact with their children are building the child’s

brain. Therefore, it is crucial to provide a safe and nurturing environment for children to explore their physical world.

- To develop a clear understanding of ‘Serve and Return’, demonstrate the following activities.

1. Peek a Boo

- Cover your face with both hands or a napkin and say “Peek-a-...” and then reveal your face and say, “boo!”
- You can change your voice, soft voice, hard voice, etc.
- Explain to the participants that it will not only enhance their communication skills but also develop bonding and attachment which is crucial for healthy brain development.



2. Mirroring

- Mirror and respond to your child's actions or sounds.
- If they smile, imitate their expression, or if they make a sound, respond with a similar sound.
- Explain that it will not only enhance their communication skills but also develop bonding and attachment that is crucial for healthy brain development.



3. Musical instruments

- Provide any musical instrument to play.
- Help the child explore the sound and texture of the provided instrument.
- This activity leads to healthy brain development.



Activity 6: Serve and Return: Reflection and Hands-on Experiences (40 minutes)

Instructions:

- Divide the participants into groups.
- Ask the groups to discuss some everyday life situations relating to the concept of serve and return.
- Demonstrate one of the activities discussed in the large group.
- Once all the groups present their work, talk about the impact of these activities on a child's brain development.

Activity 7: Stress in Early Years (30 minutes)

Instructions:

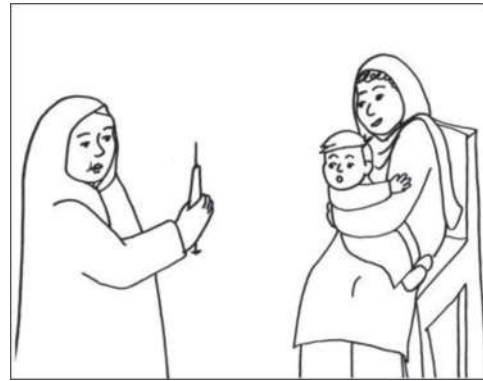
- Ask participants to share their views about the following question.
 - Do you think children get stress and depression?
 - What could be the reasons for stress?

- How does it affect a child's holistic development?
- Take the responses from participants and write down the keywords on the whiteboard.
- Discuss the types of stress, their impacts on children, and how parents can support them, with the help of facilitator's notes.

Facilitator's Notes

Childhood Stress

All children feel stressed at times. Children feel stress when there's something they need to prepare for, adapt to, or guard against. It happens when children experience changes and challenges like the first day of daycare, going to the health center for vaccination, starting a new activity, etc. It is an important and necessary aspect of healthy development, especially when it occurs in the context of stable and supportive relationships.



When Can Stress Be Helpful?

In small amounts, and when children have the right support, stress can be a positive boost. It can help children rise to a challenge. This kind of positive stress lets children build the inner strengths and skills known as resilience.

When Can Stress Be Harmful?

Stress can be harmful when children don't have a break from stress, or when they lack the support or the coping skills they need. Over time, too much stress can affect children's mental and physical health.

Parent can help their children to cope but can't save their children from stress. They can help their children by:

- Using **positive stress** to accept the changes, face the challenges, and go for goals.
- Giving support when children are going through stressful life events.
- Protecting them from the harmful effects of too much stress.



What Is Positive Stress?

Positive stress gives children the chance to grow and learn.

It is the brief stress children feel when they face a challenge. It can make them confident to focus on their goals, try new things, or get things done. Children may feel stress on the first day of school or making new friends but when they overcome the situation, the stress is gone. But if they don't know how to use that positive stress, or don't yet have the coping skills they need, it could mean a hectic race to the bus that leaves both parents and children upset.

What can parents do?

Support your child to handle the situation on their own. Rather than handling all the things and getting everything ready for their children, help them to think and find the solution. Sometimes, it takes time for the child to cope but constant parental support makes them strong to overcome the stress.

This type of positive stress can prompt children to adapt and gain the coping skills they need.

What is Tolerable Stress?

Generally, tolerable stress occurs within a time-limited period which allows the brain to recover from potentially damaging effects if the parents and caregivers are there for support. E.g. death or serious illness of a loved one, a frightening injury, or parent divorce.

What can parents do:

- Help children feel safe, loved, and cared for.
- Develop a predictable daily routine. This makes them feel that there are things they can count on.
- Practise calm breathing and meditation / religious rituals/prayers with children.
- Provide an opportunity to play. Involve them in play.
- Read books together, tell stories, play an instrument.
- If needed, take support from health professionals.



What Is Toxic Stress?

Toxic stress happens when children experience strong, frequent, and/or prolonged difficulty for example, continuous physical or emotional abuse, consistent neglect, caregiver substance abuse or mental illness, exposure to violence, and/or facing poverty without adequate adult support. This can hinder the development of the brain which increases the risk of chronic diseases like diabetes, and heart disease in later life.

What can parents do?

- Give extra support and care to their children.
- Attentively listen and talk to their children.
- Make them realize that you are there for support.
- Tell them that things will get better.
- Spend positive time together.
- Encourage children to do things they enjoy like, drawing, painting, coloring, etc.
- Give children a chance to use their strengths in everyday life.
- Consult the health care provider if needed.
- Parents can take part in the therapy and learn how to best help their child.

Developmental Domains

Activity 08: Find Someone- Bingo (20 minutes)

Instructions:

- Play bingo cards with statements like “Speaks more than one language” or “Has a sister”.

- Distribute the bingo card and a marker to each participant. (Refer to Appendix B for Bingo cards)
- Explain the following rules of the game:
 - Mingle to find who fits each statement on your bingo cards.
 - Mark off the statements/ pictures
 - Don't repeat the person.
 - Shout bingo once all the boxes are marked.
- After the activity, ask the participants to think and share which developmental domains are covered in this activity.

Activity 09: Psychosocial Development (60 minutes)

Instructions:

- Ask participants the following question to reinforce the developmental domains? (one question at a time)

Questions:

- Name the main domains of child development.
- What is language development?
- What is cognitive development?
- What is physical development?
- What is social-emotional development?

Group work: Learning Activities

Instructions:

- Divide participants into five groups and allocate an age bracket to each group.
 - Group 1: Birth to 6 months
 - Group 2: 6-12 months
 - Group 3: 12-24 months
 - Group 4: 24-36 months
 - Group 5: 36-48 months
- Provide a chart and markers to each group.
- Ask the groups to list down the activities that support cognitive, language, and social-emotional development in children for the assigned age group.
- Invite each group to present their work with the large groups.
- After each presentation, share some language, cognitive, and moral development activities given in the facilitator's notes.

Note: Participants of group two will draw the pictures/ symbols of the activities or write in the language they are comfortable in or share verbally.

Facilitator's Notes

Language Development Activities:

- Talk, read, sing, and play games with your child.

- Watch and copy your baby's sounds or gestures and respond to your baby's attempts to talk.
- Let your baby watch your face when you are talking to her/ him so he/ she can see your mouth movements clearly and hear your voice and the sounds you are making.
- 'Take turns' while talking with your child.
- Ask your child simple questions; answer your child's questions.
- Let your baby handle books.
- Sing songs to your baby.
- Even at this early age, reading to your baby exposes them to language and stimulates brain development. Choose simple board books with high-contrast images.
- Let your child see you write during daily routine activities.
- Provide writing tools and paper for your baby to explore in your presence.

Physical Development:

- Provide rattles, and small toys for your baby to grasp.
- Let your child pick finger foods and eat them.
- Give your child a spoon to eat with.
- Place your baby on their tummy for short periods while they're awake and supervised. This helps strengthen their neck and upper body muscles, preparing them for later motor skills.
- Provide opportunities for the baby to crawl and make movements.

Cognitive Development Activities:

- Provide babies with various sensory experiences, such as soft textures, rattles with different sounds, and toys with different shapes and colors.
- Engage in close face-to-face interactions with your baby. Make eye contact, smile, and talk to them. This helps develop their social and emotional brain pathways.
- Sing lullabies and play soft music for your baby. It can have a calming effect and expose them to different sounds and rhythms.
- Skin-to-skin contact through cuddling and massages helps strengthen the parent-child bond and soothes babies.
- Provide objects with different attributes (color, shape, size) and ask the participants to sort them.
- Provide age-appropriate puzzles.
- Provide building blocks to create different things.
- Play a memory game.



- Incorporate activities that focus on identifying colour, and shape identification from the environment/ objects, etc.
- Engage children in art activities including coloring, painting, printing, cutting, etc.
- Involve in simple cooking activities that require measuring and counting ingredients.
- Provide sensory activities like playing with sand and water.
- Engage children in pretend play.

Social-Emotional Development Activities:

During early years, social-emotional development is more focused on building trust and emotional bonds between children and their caregivers.

- Involve children in random acts of kindness.
- Read or tell stories that include moral lessons.
- Praise your child for their good behaviour.
- Support your child's pretend play.
- Talk with your child about his/ her feelings.
- Provide a predictable routine.
- Respond promptly to your baby's cries and needs. This helps them feel secure and establishes trust in their caregivers.
- Pay attention to your baby's emotions and respond empathetically. If they're upset, soothe them; if they're happy, engage with them. This helps babies start to recognize and understand emotions.
- Babies learn by observing their caregivers. Display empathy toward them and others, so they begin to understand how empathy works.
- Spend quality time with your baby, holding and cuddling them. A secure attachment is the foundation for developing empathy and forming healthy relationships later in life.
- Encourage interactions with other trusted caregivers, such as family members and close friends.



Activity 10: Scenario- Read the Scenario and Reflect on the Effect on a Child (60 minutes)

Instructions:

- Divide the participants into four groups and provide a scenario for each group.
- Ask them to read the scenario and discuss how each situation can positively/ negatively affect a child.
- Each group will read their scenario in a large group and share their discussed points.
- After each scenario, explain what the child is learning and how the event is impacting them. Encourage other groups to add their views also.

***Note:** Read the scenario for the participants of group two and ask them to discuss the positive/negative effects on a child's development.*

The scenarios are as follows:

Scenario 1: A one-year-old wants to play with his/ her father but every time the baby goes to him, he makes excuses to play as he is busy on his phone. What do you think will happen if the child gets a constant no from his/ her father?

Scenario 2: A two-year-old toddler goes to a mall with his / her mother. They go to the food court and have a meal. While having the meal, suddenly, the toddler starts to throw his / her food on the floor. At first, the mother calmly asks to stop but when he / she continues doing the same, she scolds him / her. The child looks around, puts his / her head down, and starts to cry. What do you think the child is feeling? How does this impact on the child?

Scenario 3: A four-year-old child along with his/ her parents is planning a meetup with his/ her friends. The child is sharing the activities he/ she would like to do with his/ her friends. Finally, they develop a plan. Parents appreciate the child for his /her amazing plan. What do you think the child will develop if he/ she gets the opportunity to plan the day or participate in making decisions?

Scenario 4: The teacher makes groups of students\having competency in different areas and assigns a task. Each child in the group contributes actively according to their competency e.g., one child will draw pictures, another will write captions for the pictures, one will manage time, etc. At the end, the teacher appreciates each group for the completion of their task.

Why did the teacher make a group of mixed-ability students? How does this help them to complete the task and how do they feel when the teacher appreciates their work?

Activity 11: Erik Erikson Psychosocial Development Theory (60 minutes)

Instructions:

- Tell the participants about the psychosocial development theory of Erik Erikson.
- Explain the stages of the theory to the participants mentioned in the facilitator's notes.
- While discussing, encourage participants to relate each stage with the scenario they have discussed in the last activity.
- Also discuss the other four stages with the participants for further knowledge.

Facilitator's Notes

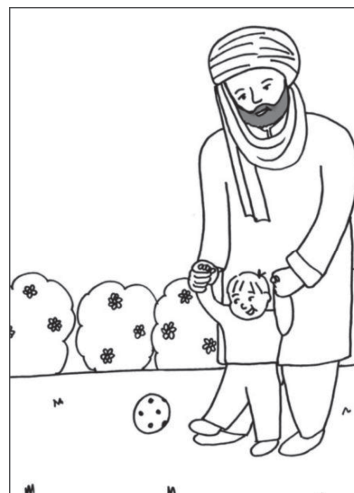
1. Trust vs. Mistrust

The first stage of Erikson's theory is the most fundamental stage in life that occurs between birth and 18 months. During this stage, an infant is dependent upon adult caregivers for everything they need to survive including food, love, safety, and nurturing. The infants are uncertain about the world in which they live. To resolve these feelings of uncertainty the infant looks towards their primary caregiver for stability and consistency of care.

If the care the infant receives is consistent, predictable, and reliable, they will develop a sense of trust that will carry with them to other relationships, and they will be able to feel secure even when threatened.

Success in this stage will lead to the virtue of **hope**. By developing a sense of trust, the infant can have hope that as new crises arise, there is a real possibility that other people will be there are a source of support. Failing to acquire the virtue of hope will lead to the development of fear.

For example, if the care received has been harsh or inconsistent, unpredictable, and unreliable, then the infant will develop a sense of mistrust and will not have confidence in the world around them or in their abilities to influence events. This infant will carry the basic sense of mistrust with them to other relationships. It may result in anxiety, heightened insecurities, and an over feeling of mistrust in the world around them.



2. Autonomy vs. Shame and Doubt

Between the ages of 18 months and three, children are developing physically and becoming more mobile. They begin to show their independence, by walking away from their mother, picking which toy to play with, and making choices about what they like to wear, to eat, etc.



The child is discovering that he or she has many skills and abilities, such as putting on clothes and shoes, playing with toys, etc. Such skills illustrate the child's growing sense of independence and autonomy. Erikson states parents must allow their children to explore the limits of their abilities within an encouraging environment which is tolerant of failure. For example, rather than put on a child's clothes a supportive parent should have the patience to allow the child to try until they succeed or ask for assistance. So, the parents need to encourage the child to become more independent whilst at the same time protecting the child so that constant failure is avoided.

Success in this stage will lead to the virtue of **will**.

If children in this stage are encouraged and supported in their increased independence, they become more confident and secure in their own ability to survive in the world. If children are criticised, overly controlled, or not given the opportunity to assert themselves, they begin to feel inadequate in their ability to survive and may then become overly dependent upon others and may feel a sense of shame or doubt in their abilities.

3. Initiative vs. Guilt

Around age three to age five, children assert themselves more frequently. These are particularly lively, rapidly developing years in a child's life. According to Bee (1992), it is a "time of vigor of action and of behaviours that the parents may see as aggressive".



During this period, the main feature involves the child regularly interacting with other children at school. Central to this stage is play, as it provides children with the opportunity to explore their interpersonal skills through initiating activities.

Children begin to plan activities, make up games, and initiate activities with others. If given this opportunity, children develop a sense of initiative and feel secure in their ability to lead others and make decisions.

Conversely, if this tendency is squelched, either through criticism or control, children develop a sense of guilt. They may feel like a nuisance to others and will therefore remain followers, lacking in self-initiative. The child takes initiative which the parents will often try to stop to protect the child. The child will often overstep the mark in his / her forcefulness and the danger is that the parents will tend to punish the child and restrict their initiatives too much.

At this stage, the child will begin to ask many questions as the thirst for knowledge grows. If the parents treat the child's questions as trivial, a nuisance, or embarrassing or other aspects of their behaviour as threatening then the child may have feelings of guilt for "being a nuisance".

Too much guilt can make the child slow to interact with others and may inhibit their creativity. Some guilt is, of course, necessary, otherwise the child would not know how to exercise self-control or have a conscience. A healthy balance between initiative and guilt is important. Success in this stage will lead to the virtue of **purpose**.

4. Industry (competence) vs. Inferiority

This stage occurs between the ages of five and twelve. Children are at the stage where they will be learning to read and write, to do sums, and to do things on their own. Teachers begin to take an important role in the child's life as they teach the child specific skills.



At this stage, the child's peer group will gain greater significance and will become a major source of the child's self-esteem. The child now feels the need to win approval by demonstrating specific competencies that are valued by society and begins to develop a sense of pride in their accomplishments.

If children are encouraged and reinforced for their initiative, they begin to feel confident in their ability to achieve goals. If this initiative is not encouraged by parents or teachers, then the child begins to feel inferior, doubting his/ her abilities, and therefore may not reach his or her potential. If the child cannot develop the specific skill, they feel society is demanding (e.g. being athletic) then they may develop a sense of inferiority. Some failure may be necessary so that the child can develop some modesty. Yet again, a balance between competence and modesty is necessary. Success in this stage will lead to the virtue of **competence**.

5. Identity vs. Role Confusion

This stage occurs from about 12-18 years. During this stage, adolescents search for a sense of self and personal identity, through an intense exploration of personal values, beliefs, and goals. The adolescent mind is essentially a mind in moratorium, a psychosocial stage between childhood and adulthood, and between the morality learned by the child, and the ethics to be developed by the adult (Erikson, 1963, p. 245)

During adolescence, the transition from childhood to adulthood is most important. Children are becoming more independent, and begin to look at the future in terms of careers, relationships, families, housing, etc. The individual wants to belong to a society and fit in.

This is a major stage in development where the child has to learn the roles he/she will occupy as an adult. It is during this stage that the adolescent will re-examine his / her identity and try to find out exactly who he or she is. Erikson suggests that two identities are involved: the sexual and the occupational.

According to Bee (1992), what should happen at the end of this stage is "a reintegrated sense of self, of what one wants to do or be, and of one's appropriate sex role". During this stage the body image of the adolescent changes. Erikson claims that the adolescent may feel uncomfortable about their body for a while until they can adapt and "grow into" the changes. Success in this stage will lead to the virtue of **fidelity**.

Fidelity involves being able to commit one's self to others based on accepting others, even when there may be ideological differences.

During this period, they explore possibilities and begin to form their own identity based on the outcome of their explorations. Failure to establish a sense of identity within society ("I don't know what I want to be when I grow up") can lead to role confusion. Role confusion involves the individual not being sure about themselves or their place in society.

In response to role confusion or **identity crisis**, an adolescent may begin to experiment with different lifestyles (e.g. work, education, or political activities). Also pressuring someone into an identity can result in rebellion in the form of establishing a negative identity, and in addition to this feeling of unhappiness.

6. Intimacy vs. Isolation

Occurring in young adulthood (ages 18 to 40 years), we begin to share ourselves more intimately with others. We explore relationships leading toward longer-term commitments with someone other than a family member.

Successful completion of this stage can lead to comfortable relationships and a sense of commitment, safety, and care within a relationship. Avoiding intimacy, and fearing commitment and relationships can lead to isolation, loneliness, and sometimes depression. Success in this stage will lead to the virtue of **love**.

7. Generativity vs. Stagnation

During middle adulthood (ages 40 to 65 years), we establish our careers, settle down within a relationship, begin our own families, and develop a sense of being a part of the bigger picture. We give back to society through raising our children, being productive at work, and becoming involved in community activities and organizations.

By failing to achieve these objectives, we become stagnant and feel unproductive. Success in this stage will lead to the virtue of **care**.

8. Ego Integrity vs. Despair

As we grow older (65+ years) and become senior citizens, we tend to slow down our productivity and explore life as a retired person. It is during this time that we contemplate our accomplishments and can develop integrity if we see ourselves as leading a successful life.

Erik Erikson believed if we see our lives as unproductive, feel guilty about our past, or feel that we did not accomplish our life goals, we become dissatisfied with life and develop despair, often leading to depression and hopelessness.

Success in this stage will lead to the virtue of **wisdom**. Wisdom enables a person to look back on their life with a sense of closure and completeness, and also accept death without fear.

Physical Development

Activity 12: Physical Development: Origami Aeroplane (30 minutes)

Instruction:

- Provide A4 size color paper to each participant.
- Ask them to make an origami aeroplane.
- Assist if anyone needs to know the steps of an origami aeroplane.
- Once everyone is done with the task, take the participants outside in the ground/ open space.
- Ask them to fly their aeroplane and see how far it goes.
- Bring the participants back and ask the following questions:
 - How did you feel while doing this activity?
 - Was the activity challenging?
 - What development took place during the making and flying of the aeroplane?
- After taking responses from the participants, talk briefly about physical development, given in the facilitator's notes.

Facilitator's Notes

Physical development is one of the key domains of learning and development. It plays a crucial role as children learn to master control over their bodies. As children grow and develop, these changes are easily noticed. They are viewed as markers along life's journey, which are referred to as developmental milestones.

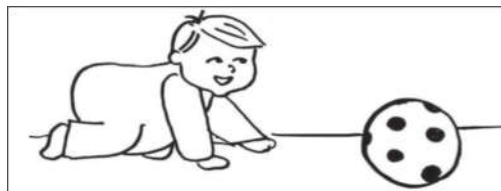
Physical development is also known as motor development. A child's physical or motor development falls into two categories:

1. Fine motor skills
2. Gross motor skills

1. **Fine Motor:** also called small muscle skills, involve smaller movements that occur in the fingers, wrists, hands, feet, and toes. For instance, writing, coloring, tearing, and cutting are fine motor skills. Children must develop fine motor skills at an early stage as these skills will help the child interact effectively with the environment.



2. **Gross Motor:** also known as large muscles skills, are referred to as the movement and coordination of the large body parts including arms and legs. Mainly involves full-body movements, for example running, jumping, swimming, and crawling. Gross motor skills are also important as these help us in performing everyday functions. Generally, these skills follow a pattern of development



from head to toe. Engaging children in outdoor play is essential to develop better gross motor skills.

Activity 13: Motor Skills Activities (40 minutes)

Instructions:

- Divide the participants into five small groups.
- Allocate each group to an age bracket.
 - Group 1- Birth to 1 year
 - Group 2- 2 to 3 years
 - Group 3- 4 to 5 years
 - Group 4 – 5 to 6 years
- Provide a flip chart and broad markers to each group.
- Give the following instructions:
 - List down age-appropriate activities that support motor development in children of their specific age group.
 - Prepare any activities from your list to give practical demonstrations in the large group.
- Each group will share the list of activities and give demonstrations of one activity.
- Encourage the other groups to add activities to the shared list.

Note: Ask the participants of group two to show the activities with the help of simple/ stick drawing/ short phrases in any language.

Activity 14: Concept of Play (20 minutes)

Instructions:

- Provide crayons, pencil colors, and A4 size-page paper to each participant.
- Ask them to fold the paper into four sections and then unfold it.
- Tell participants that in this activity you need to draw only. No writing is required.
- Start the activity by giving the following instructions.
 - Section 1- Draw your favorite childhood play.
 - Section 2- Draw the play that you enjoyed with your friends in your childhood.
 - Section 3- Draw the play you enjoyed alone.
 - Section 4- Draw the play you enjoy with your child/ children.
- Ask the participants to show their work and share their learning from these play activities.
- Select activities randomly from each section and take responses from them.

Activity 15: Importance of Play (20 minutes)

Instructions:

- Ask the following questions from the participants:
 - What is the right age for a child to play?
 - How does play help in a child's development?
- Talk about the importance of play in a child's holistic development with the help of facilitator's notes.

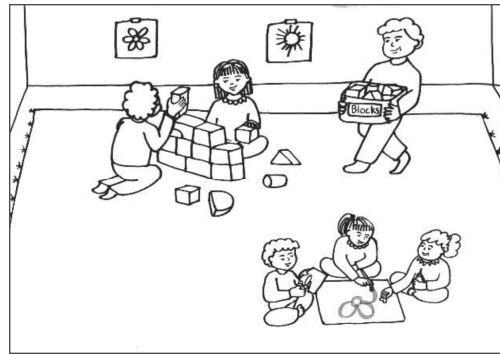
Facilitator's Notes

Why is play important?

In the early years, a child's main way of learning and developing is through play. Play is fun for a child. It allows him/her to explore, observe, experiment, solve problems, and sometimes make mistakes. Positive, stimulating, and playful experiences lay the foundations for healthy brain development, otherwise, the absence of such experience can have negative effects on the brain.

Play also helps a child to:

- express his/ her feelings and ideas.
- to form a strong bond with their parents. Even a simple game like peekaboo can become a special bonding moment for both parents and children. These interactions contribute to positive life experiences that stimulate children's brain development.
- develop their social skills. Unstructured active play with others, including parents, siblings, and peers, is a significant opportunity to develop social skills. While playing together, children learn to cooperate, develop empathy, follow the rules, develop self-control, and generally get along with other people. These children develop a better understanding of other people's feelings and beliefs.
- practice their vocabulary when they speak and try to understand others. While playing with other children, they often use each other's words and actions to reach agreements.
- develop fine motor skills as well as gross. Lots of play activities require children to manipulate smaller objects in specific ways. This might be Peek-a-Boo, coloring in a picture, dressing a doll in clothes, building with blocks, or even using tools on an activity tray.



Activity 16: Play with low/ No Cost Resources (30 minutes)

Instructions:

- Ask participants the following questions.
 - How much time do you think a child should get to play daily?
 - Is it necessary to have toys for play?
 - What types of play would you recommend for a child?
- Take random responses and share the following points with the participants.
 - Play is a basic right of children.
 - As discussed earlier, it plays a crucial role in their holistic development impacting both positively and negatively depending on the nature of their play experiences.
 - Children should have a good time to play daily, it could be a combination of free and guided play.
 - Children don't need toys every time they play. They can initiate play with any available resources.

- Now, divide the participants into small groups.
- Provide a bag with different low/no-cost resources to each group.
- Ask each group to develop an activity using the provided resources.
- Each group will demonstrate the activity they have designed.
- Ask other groups to share their ideas.

Activity 17: “Play in the Past” and “Play is Now” (20 minutes)

Instruction:

- Draw two columns on the whiteboard. Label each with “Play in the Past” and “Play Now.”
- Ask the participants to share the changes like play that have occurred since their childhood.
- Once the groups share their work, explain to them that play has been changed in many ways, like nowadays:
 - Children do not get a chance to play outdoors every day.
 - Children are not getting enough time to play every day.
 - Children are spending more time on screen.
- Furthermore, talk about screen time with the help of the facilitator’s notes.

Facilitator’s Notes

Screen time is a term used for activities done in front of a screen such as watching television, playing games on computers, laptops, smartphones, and using video game consoles. Screen time is a sedentary activity and is mostly performed by being physically inactive while sitting or lying down. (MedlinePlus 2021).

Health experts’ recommendations for screen time for children

According to the World Health Organization and the American Academy of Paediatrics, children aged 0-2 years old should have no screen time. This includes television viewing. However, during times of uncertainty and when family members may live far away, brief daily video chats or telephone calls with family members are acceptable as it is considered quality time interacting with others. Children aged between 2 to 4, can start to enjoy some screen time with a parent or caregiver but should have no more than one hour of screen time per day.

Key Takeaways: Developmental Domains

- The experiences in the womb can have an impact on brain development therefore it is crucial to recognise the importance of supporting prenatal health and nutrition.
- Before birth and during early childhood there are especially sensitive periods for specific areas of the brain when brain cells are connecting and creating pathways and developing key skills.
- After birth, breast milk has all the nutrients for brain development and therefore supporting moms to breastfeed supports healthy early brain development.
- Along with good nutrition, a healthy brain needs stimulation.
- Back-and-forth interactions between a baby and their caregivers are an important ingredient in early brain development.
- The experiences and adult support children have in early childhood help them to respond to daily stresses and challenges.
- Cognitive development among children is related to how they process information in their brains. It is related to critical thinking, learning new things, remembering, making decisions, and solving problems.
- Reading and storytelling with infants and toddlers promote brain development, imagination, language, and learning.
- The first 3 years of life are the most intensive time for acquiring language skills.
- The literacy experiences that children have before they start school form powerful brain connections. These connections are used for language, thinking, and understanding. Activities like talking, singing, reading, scribbling, and drawing, are important to develop these important connections.
- From birth, a baby begins to sort out the speech sounds that make up the words of their home language. By 6 months, most babies recognize the basic sounds of their home language.
- For children to learn an additional language, it is important to have command over the home language.
- From birth, children learn to read and write in a print-rich environment, seeing adults and other children read and write.

- Listening to stories exposes babies to more words, builds their vocabulary, and develops their thinking skills.
- Telling stories and singing rhymes with emotion and expression supports babies' social and emotional development.
- Writing development happens in stages beginning with mark-making and scribbling before pre-school years.
- Play helps children to stay healthy, express emotions, learn new things, test out ideas, be imaginative and creative, make choices, make mistakes, solve problems, develop independence, and make friends. It cannot be replaced by a screen.